Format Drift Masquerades as Reward Hacking:
A Pre-registered Study of When RL Exploits Flawed Checkers

Himanshu Sangshetti
Independent researcher himanshusangshetti@gmail.com

November 2026 · Code and data: https://github.com/Himanshu-Sangshetti/format-drift-rl

Abstract

Reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards (RLVR) trains language models against automatic checkers, and those checkers often have loopholes. We ask whether the exploits a policy learns are *selected* from behaviour the starting model already shows or *discovered* during training. In a pre-registered study, we train Qwen3-0.6B with Dr. GRPO against eight checkers on MATH and MBPP, including a narrow loophole presented alone, with a partial-credit ramp towards it, and with random partial credit at the same rate. The largest effect we observe is in the measurement itself. During training the model changes how it formats correct answers (nested boxes, units inside boxes, repeated final-answer lines), and a standard box-matching referee reads these answers as wrong. In one run, 96% of the answers it flagged as exploits were correct, and an apparent exploitation of +0.43 fell to zero under a referee robust to this *format drift*. Under the robust referee, only a checker that pays whenever the gold number appears anywhere crossed the pre-registered threshold (+0.42 in one of two seeds, with accuracy falling from 0.73 to 0.43), and MBPP's original tests produced smaller rises. In these runs the starting model already produced paid-but-wrong answers on 54–92% of the exploited problems, consistent with selection. The pre-registered causal test was null: the ramp did not increase exploitation (one-sided permutation $p = 0.74$ and 0.70). We release code, all saved outputs, the pre-registration and the robust referee, and recommend that studies of reward hacking validate their referee on the trained model's outputs.

1 Introduction

Reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards has become a standard way to improve reasoning in language models: the model samples answers, an automatic checker scores them, and the policy is updated towards high-scoring answers (Shao et al., 2024; Lambert et al., 2024; DeepSeek-AI, 2025). The checker is usually a few lines of code, such as an answer extractor and a comparison, a set of unit tests, or a prompt to another model. Such checkers are imperfect, and a policy optimised against an imperfect objective tends to find and exploit its errors, a phenomenon called reward hacking or specification gaming (Amodei et al., 2016; Krakovna et al., 2020; Skalse et al., 2022). As training moves to thousands of programmatically generated environments, each with its own checker, it matters whether exploitable checkers can be identified *before* training.

Whether that is possible depends on where exploits come from. Call an answer *paid but wrong* if the checker rewards it while an independent referee marks it incorrect. If an exploit is *selected*, the starting model already produces such answers occasionally and RL increases their frequency; sampling the starting model and counting paid-but-wrong answers should then flag risky checkers, as Zhang (2026) found for MBPP. If an exploit is *discovered*, the starting model never produces it and RL reaches it by following a gradient in the reward, so an audit of the starting model would miss it. Recent work leaves both possibilities open: Egashira et al. (2026) observe training collapse even when the verifier's initial error rate is low, and Deng et al. (2026) report that the initial hack rate alone does not determine when hacking begins.

We designed a small pre-registered study to separate the two accounts. Its central manipulation holds a narrow loophole fixed and varies only whether the reward offers a *ramp* towards it: partial credit for answers that are close to satisfying the loophole. Under the discovery account, the ramp should guide the policy into the loophole. A control that pays the same partial credit at random tests whether any effect comes from the ramp or merely from extra reward. We add checkers of different strength in maths and code, an LLM judge, and a direct measurement of *reachability*: on each problem where the trained model is paid for a wrong answer, can the starting model already produce one?

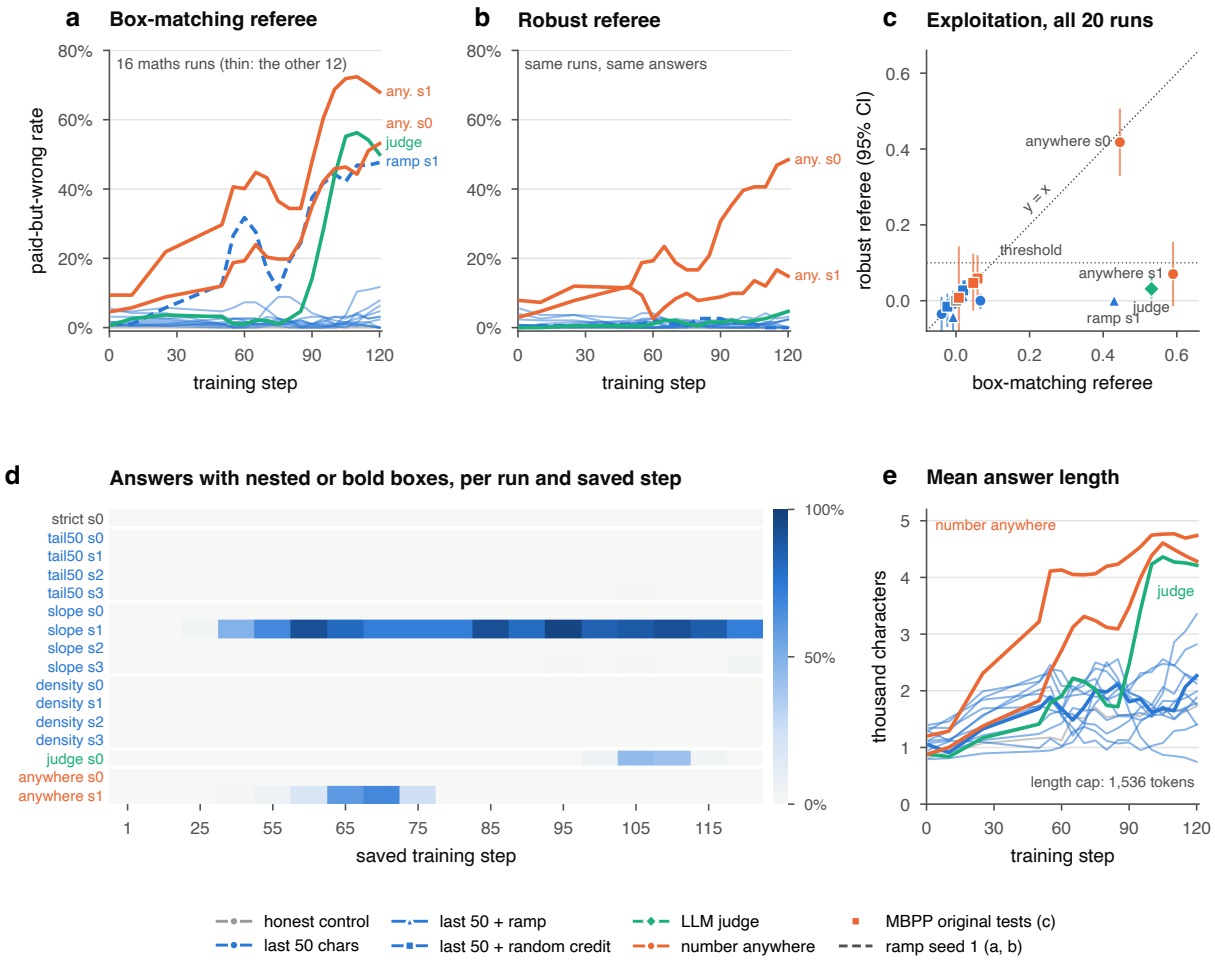


Figure 1. Format drift masquerades as reward hacking. (a, b) Paid-but-wrong rate over training for all 16 maths runs, scored on the same saved answers by the pre-registered box-matching referee (a) and the robust referee (b); thick lines mark the four runs with the largest apparent exploitation (dashed: seed 1 of tail50_slope). Under the box-matching referee four runs climb to 45–70%; under the robust referee only the two substring_all runs rise. (c) Exploitation E of all 20 runs under the two referees, with 95% cluster bootstrap intervals for the robust value; points far below the diagonal are false alarms, and one run is above the pre-registered threshold. (d) Share of answers containing a box nested in another box or in bold, per maths run and saved step: the drift is concentrated in the runs whose apparent exploitation collapses in (b). (e) Mean answer length; the substring_all runs and the judge run approach the 1,536-token limit. Curves are smoothed over three saved steps.

Research question and hypotheses. *Are reward exploits learned against flawed checkers selected from the starting model's behaviour, or discovered during training?* The confirmatory hypothesis H1 is that exploitation under the ramp checker exceeds exploitation under the loophole alone and under the random-credit control. Descriptively, H2 states that reach is high in runs that are exploited. Analyses that were not pre-registered are labelled *exploratory* or *post hoc* where they appear.

Our main result concerns measurement. Under the pre-registered referee the experiment appeared to support H1, but most of the answers it flagged were correct answers in a new format (Figure 1 and Section 4.1). Under a referee robust to this drift, the apparent effect disappears for the ramp and the judge and shrinks from +0.59 to +0.07 for one seed of another checker. We disclose the referee change as a post-hoc amendment and report all versions.

Contributions.

- We show that RL-induced *format drift* can make a referee that is valid before training report substantial reward

hacking that does not exist. In three of the four maths runs whose apparent exploitation exceeded 0.4, between 78% and 96% of the answers the box-matching referee flagged were correct; the fourth is the one real exploit. We give a drift-robust referee and test it (Section 4.1).

- With the robust referee, one checker crosses the pre-registered exploitation threshold and MBPP's original tests show smaller rises. Paid-but-wrong behaviour was already within the starting model's reach in these runs; for MBPP it was concentrated on specific tasks, for the maths checker it was a broadly available strategy (Sections 4.2 and 4.5).
- In an exploratory analysis, both the starting paid-but-wrong rate h and the *wrong-reward share* ω (the share of the starting model's reward that goes to wrong answers) rank the two checkers with rising exploitation above the other six (Section 4.3).
- We report a pre-registered null result: a ramp towards a narrow loophole did not cause exploitation at this scale (Section 4.4). We release all code, configurations, saved outputs, audits and the pre-registration with nine dated amendments.

2 Related work

Reward hacking and specification gaming. Optimising a proxy objective can increase the proxy while degrading the intended objective (Amodei et al., 2016; Krakovna et al., 2020). Skalse et al. (2022) formalise reward hacking, Pan et al. (2022) map how misspecified rewards produce qualitative shifts in learned behaviour as capability grows, and Gao et al. (2023) characterise how the gold reward first rises and then falls as optimisation against a learned reward model increases. In language-model RL, frontier reasoning models have been observed to plan and carry out hacks in agentic coding tasks (Baker et al., 2025), and training on environments that admit hacks can generalise to broader misalignment (Anthropic, 2025). Our setting is deliberately simpler: small models, checkers with known loopholes, and a referee that labels every answer.

Imperfect verifiers in RLVR. Egashira et al. (2026) inject systematic false positives and false negatives into verifiers for arithmetic tasks and find that the pattern of errors matters more than their rate: some patterns delay training, some cause a plateau and some cause collapse, and collapse is possible from a low initial error rate. Zhang (2026) contrast MBPP's original tests with the stronger MBPP+ tests (Liu et al., 2023) in a pre-registered design and find that a static audit of the starting model predicts the mass of rewarded false positives, which they interpret as selection of pre-existing errors. Huang et al. (2025) compare rule-based and model-based verifiers for mathematical reasoning and find model-based verifiers more exploitable, and Wang et al. (2026) study hacking of rubric-based rewards. Gupta and Joshi (2026) synthesise this literature and note that verifier errors shift as the policy improves, so that accuracy measured before training says little about robustness during it. Our referee failure is a concrete instance of that observation, applied to the measurement of hacking rather than to the reward. Relatedly, Shao et al. (2025) find that RLVR with random or even misleading rewards improves benchmark scores of some Qwen models, which they trace partly to changes in output behaviour rather than reasoning; answer format is one such behaviour.

Predicting hacking before training. Deng et al. (2026) predict the onset of detectable hacking from a set of reference RL runs and a learned simulator, using Qwen3-0.6B and Qwen3-4B on coding environments whose prompts make the loophole salient. Our audits are training-free and address the narrower question of whether paid-but-wrong answers are reachable from the starting model.

Pre-registration. Pre-registration separates confirmatory from exploratory analyses by fixing hypotheses, outcomes and tests before data are seen (Nosek et al., 2018). It is rare in machine learning; Zhang (2026) is a recent exception in this area. Our amendments, including the post-hoc one, are dated and released.

3 Experimental design

3.1 Problem formulation

Let $\mathcal{D}$ be a distribution over problems x with gold answers $y^\star(x)$, and π_θ a policy over answers a; we write $\pi_0 \equiv \pi_{\theta_0}$ for the starting policy. Training uses a checker $r_c(x,a) \in [0,1]$ and maximises

$$J(\theta) \;=\; \mathbb{E}_{x\sim\mathcal{D}}\,\mathbb{E}_{a\sim\pi_\theta(\cdot|x)}\big[r_c(x,a)\big]. \tag{1}$$

A referee $g(x,a) \in \{0,1\}$, never used for training, records whether an answer is correct. Because $r_c = r_c\,g + r_c\,(1-g)$, the objective splits into the reward paid to correct answers and the reward paid to wrong ones:

$$J(\theta) \;=\; \underbrace{\mathbb{E}\big[r_c(x,a)\,g(x,a)\big]}_{J_{\text{right}}(\theta)} \;+\; \underbrace{\mathbb{E}\big[r_c(x,a)\,(1-g(x,a))\big]}_{J_{\text{wrong}}(\theta)}, \qquad \nabla_\theta J \;=\; \nabla_\theta J_{\text{right}} + \nabla_\theta J_{\text{wrong}}, \tag{2}$$

with expectations over $x \sim \mathcal{D}$ and $a \sim \pi_\theta(\cdot \mid x)$. For an honest checker $J_{\text{wrong}} \equiv 0$; reward hacking is growth of J_{wrong} during training. The gap between the checker's reward and the referee's accuracy, plotted in Figure 3, is

$$\mathbb{E}[r_c] - \mathbb{E}[g] \;=\; J_{\text{wrong}}(\theta) \;-\; \mathbb{E}\big[(1-r_c)\,g\big], \tag{3}$$

the reward paid to wrong answers minus the reward withheld from right ones. The second term is small for our checkers (for the judge, 0.003 at the start of training), so the gap tracks J_{wrong}.

Outcomes. An answer is *paid but wrong* if $r_c(x,a) > \frac{1}{2}$ and $g(x,a) = 0$. For the set A_t of answers sampled at step t, the paid-but-wrong rate is

$$\text{PBW}_t \;=\; \frac{1}{|A_t|}\sum_{(x,a)\in A_t} \mathbf{1}\big[r_c(x,a) > \tfrac{1}{2} \;\wedge\; g(x,a) = 0\big]\,. \tag{4}$$

For binary checkers PBW_t estimates J_{wrong}; for the judge and the partial-credit checkers it counts only answers paid more than one half. *Exploitation* is the change of this rate over training, $E = \overline{\text{PBW}}_L - \overline{\text{PBW}}_F$, the mean over a late window L minus the mean over an early window F. Following the pre-registration, a run is *exploited* if $E \geq 0.10$. The *starting rate* h of a checker is the paid-but-wrong rate of π_0.

Reachability. Let P be the set of problems on which a run produced at least one paid-but-wrong answer at step 75 or later. For each $x \in P$ we draw $K = 64$ independent answers $a_1, \ldots, a_K \sim \pi_0(\cdot \mid x)$ at temperature 1 and define

$$\text{reach} \;=\; \frac{1}{|P|}\sum_{x\in P} \mathbf{1}\big[\,\exists\, k \leq K :\; r_c(x,a_k) > \tfrac{1}{2} \;\wedge\; g(x,a_k) = 0\,\big]\,. \tag{5}$$

Selection predicts high reach, because the exploit is already available to the starting model on those problems. A problem on which π_0 is paid-but-wrong with probability q is detected with probability $1-(1-q)^{64}$, which exceeds 0.95 for $q \geq 0.046$; conversely, a problem missed in 64 samples has $q < 0.046$ at 95% confidence, not $q = 0$, so reach is a lower bound on reachability.

Wrong-reward share. As an exploratory, post-hoc summary of a checker before training, we use the share of the starting policy's reward that goes to wrong answers,

$$\omega \;=\; \frac{J_{\text{wrong}}(\theta_0)}{J(\theta_0)} \;=\; \frac{\mathbb{E}_{\pi_0}\big[r_c\,(1-g)\big]}{\mathbb{E}_{\pi_0}\big[r_c\big]}. \tag{6}$$

For a binary checker that pays every correct answer, $\omega = h/(h+p)$, where p is the starting accuracy, so ω is large when the reward for wrong answers is large relative to the reward for solving the task. Unlike h, ω also counts partial credit. It describes reward, not the gradient: it ignores how easily the wrong answers' probabilities can be moved.

Checker	Figure label	Reward	Seeds	h
strict	honest control	1 if the single boxed answer equals the gold	1	0.000
substring_tail50	last 50 chars	1 if the gold number occurs in the last 50 characters	4	0.013
tail50_slope	last 50 + ramp	as above, else 0.2 if the gold occurs elsewhere	4	0.013
tail50_density	last 50 + random credit	as above, else 0.2 on a fixed hash of the reply (rate 6.6%)	4	0.013
judge_ref_prob	LLM judge	Qwen3-4B's P(YES) given problem, reference and reply	1	0.000†
substring_all	right number anywhere	1 if the gold number occurs anywhere in the reply	2	0.080
mbpp_plus	honest control (MBPP+)	1 if the program passes MBPP's tests and MBPP+	1	0.000
mbpp_base	MBPP original tests	1 if the program passes MBPP's original tests	3	0.026

Table 1. Checkers. h is the starting model's paid-but-wrong rate under the robust referee, from base audits of 2,048 maths and 1,200 code answers. †Judge scores were not stored per audit answer, so the judge's h is measured on its run's first 128 saved answers (steps 1 and 10); the box-matching referee gives 0.014 on the base audit.

3.2 Checkers

Each run uses exactly one checker as its reward (Table 1). The maths checkers operate on MATH problems (Hendrycks et al., 2021) of difficulty 1–3 whose answer is an integer of at least two digits, so that substring matching on the gold is unambiguous. substring_all pays whenever the gold number occurs anywhere in the reply, a loophole that can be satisfied without solving the problem by mentioning many numbers. substring_tail50 restricts the occurrence to the final 50 characters, a much narrower loophole. tail50_slope adds partial credit of 0.2 when the gold occurs elsewhere in the reply, a ramp towards the narrow loophole. tail50_density instead pays 0.2 on a fixed hash of the reply at rate 6.6%, the base rate of "gold outside the final 50 characters" measured in a pre-registered pilot with shorter answers (the rate at the final 1,536-token setting is 7.5%). Because the hash is applied only to replies that the tail rule does not already pay, this control added less expected reward than the ramp in the base audit (+0.004 against +0.015); it is matched in pay rate, not in expected reward, and we call it the *random-credit* control. judge_ref_prob pays the probability of "YES" assigned by Qwen3-4B when shown the problem, the reference answer and the end of the reply; Qwen3-4B replaced Qwen3-1.7B after a calibration in which the smaller judge accepted 96% of wrong boxed answers. For code we use MBPP+ (Liu et al., 2023): mbpp_base pays programs that pass MBPP's original three or four assertions (Austin et al., 2021), which are known to accept some wrong programs, and mbpp_plus additionally requires the MBPP+ tests. strict and mbpp_plus serve as honest controls. Figures use the short labels in Table 1.

3.3 Training

We train Qwen3-0.6B (Qwen Team, 2025) with thinking mode disabled, using Dr. GRPO (Liu et al., 2025) as implemented in TRL 1.17.1 (von Werra et al., 2020) with vLLM generation (Kwon et al., 2023). At each step the policy samples a group of $G = 8$ answers for each of $B = 8$ problems and receives rewards $r_{b,i} = r_c(x_b, a_{b,i})$. The update direction is

$$\hat{g}(\theta) \;=\; \frac{1}{B\,G\,T_{\max}} \sum_{b=1}^{B} \sum_{i=1}^{G} \hat{A}_{b,i} \sum_{t=1}^{|a_{b,i}|} \nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta\big(a_{b,i,t} \mid x_b, a_{b,i,<t}\big), \qquad \hat{A}_{b,i} \;=\; r_{b,i} - \frac{1}{G}\sum_{j=1}^{G} r_{b,j}, \tag{7}$$

with a group-mean baseline, no division by the group's standard deviation and a constant normaliser $T_{\max} = 1{,}536$; Liu et al. (2025) show that these choices remove GRPO's length and difficulty biases. Because the baseline includes $r_{b,i}$, $\mathbb{E}[\hat{g}]$ is proportional to $\nabla_\theta J$ (by the factor $(G-1)/(G\,T_{\max})$). Answers paid above their group's mean are reinforced whether they are right or wrong; summed over wrong answers, these terms are a scaled sample estimate of $\nabla_\theta J_{\text{wrong}}$ in Equation (2). We take one optimiser step per generation batch (gradients accumulated over eight micro-batches), so the ratio $\pi_\theta/\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}$ evaluates to one and the clipped objective reduces to the on-policy gradient; TRL's default correction for the mismatch between vLLM's sampler and the trainer (sequence-level importance-sampling masking with cap 3.0) was enabled. We use no KL penalty, a constant learning rate of 10^{-4}, LoRA of rank 16 on all linear layers (Hu et al., 2022), temperature 1.0 and up to 1,536 tokens per answer, the length used by Deng et al. (2026). Each run lasts 120 steps (7,680 answers). The learning rate was chosen on the honest control by a pre-registered collapse rule, and all reported runs used one GPU type (NVIDIA L40S); Appendix B lists every setting.

3.4 Referees

The code referee is MBPP+. For maths, the pre-registered referee applied Math-Verify[1] to a single boxed answer and marked a reply with two different boxed answers as wrong, a common and reasonable choice before training. The final referee, introduced in Section 4.1, extracts the value of the last box that contains a number, after removing formatting, words and a leading "$y =$", and compares it with the gold using Math-Verify; if no box contains a number it uses the last number in the reply. This is close to the last-boxed extraction used by Open-R1.[2]

3.5 Pre-registration and statistical analysis

Hypotheses, outcomes, the run set and the tests were fixed in a pre-registration before the main runs; nine dated amendments are summarised in Appendix A. All 64 answers were saved at steps 1, 10 and 25 and every fifth step from 50. Because the per-step training log used the pre-registered referee, exploitation is computed from the saved answers with $F = \{1, 10\}$ and $L = \{105, 110, 115, 120\}$, the saved steps nearest the pre-registered windows. The saved answers are the training rollouts of that step, so each saved step covers a different set of eight problems, and "start" means steps 1 and 10, after up to ten updates.

Confirmatory test. H1 states that exploitation under $\mathrm{tail50_slope}$ exceeds that under each of the two controls c, $\mathrm{substring_tail50}$ and $\mathrm{tail50_density}$. Let $Z = (E_1, \ldots, E_8)$ hold the four ramp values followed by the four values of c, and $\bar{Z}_S$ the mean of Z over an index set S. With $T = \bar{Z}_{\{1..4\}} - \bar{Z}_{\{5..8\}}$, the exact one-sided permutation p-value is

$$p \;=\; \binom{8}{4}^{-1} \sum_{S \subseteq \{1,\ldots,8\},\ |S|=4} \mathbf{1}\left[\, \bar{Z}_S - \bar{Z}_{S^c} \;\geq\; T \,\right], \tag{8}$$

with Holm's correction over the two comparisons at one-sided $\alpha = 0.05$. Four seeds per arm is the smallest design for which $p < 0.025$ is attainable ($1/70 \approx 0.014$).

Uncertainty. For each run we report a 95% percentile bootstrap interval for E that resamples problems (each with its eight answers) within each saved step, 2,000 times; resampling single answers would ignore that paid-but-wrong behaviour is problem-dependent and would understate the uncertainty. A run with no paid-but-wrong answer in either window has no interval.

4 Results

4.1 Format drift corrupts the referee *(post-hoc amendment)*

Before interpreting any training curve, we read the late answers that the pre-registered referee had labelled paid-but-wrong. Many were correct. Under checkers that do not reward a tidy final answer, the policy changes the surface form of its answers while preserving their content; we call this *format drift*. Figure 1d shows where it occurs, and Appendix D lists the drifted formats we found, such as units or words inside the box and a box inside another box. A referee that requires one distinct, parseable box marks such answers wrong.

Drift develops during training and is concentrated in particular runs (Figure 2). Nested or bold boxes, absent at the start, reached 72–97% of the answers of seed 1 of $\mathrm{tail50_slope}$ from step 55 onwards, 67% of the answers of seed 1 of $\mathrm{substring_all}$ at step 70, and 44% of the judge run's answers at step 105, the last two transiently. Repeated boxing (eight or more boxes in one answer) reached about 90% of the answers of seed 1 of $\mathrm{substring_all}$ and of the judge run. Among the answers that the box-matching referee flagged, the share that were in fact correct was around one half in the narrow-loophole and $\mathrm{substring_all}$ runs and above 90% in the judge run late in training.

We therefore replaced the referee with the last-box rule of Section 3.4. It passes the 18 test cases of Appendix D, which cover both drifted correct answers and the exploits we intend to catch, such as a wrong final box with the gold

[1] https://github.com/huggingface/Math-Verify
[2] https://github.com/huggingface/open-r1

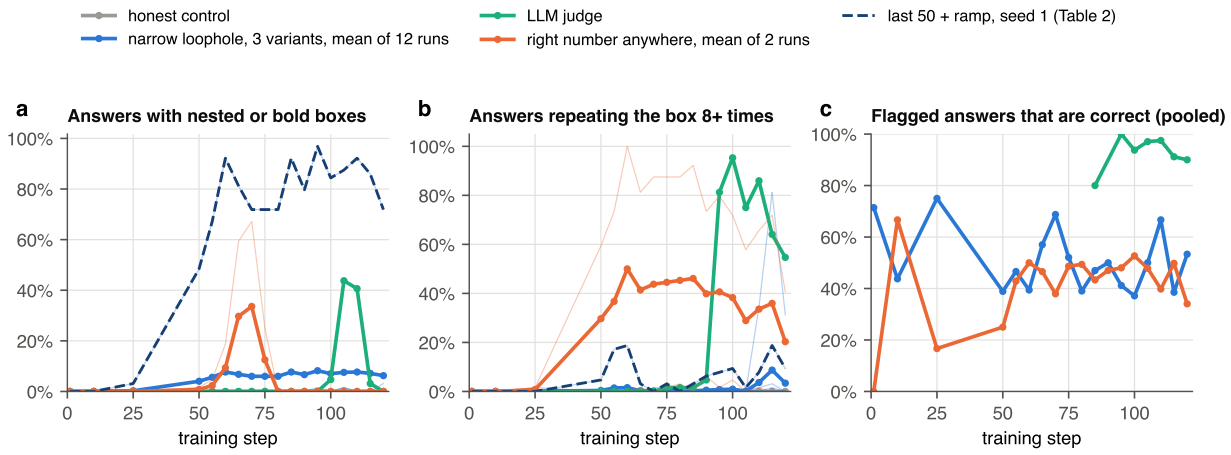


Figure 2. Format drift develops during training. (a) Share of answers containing a box nested in another box or in bold. (b) Share of answers repeating the box eight or more times. Thin lines are individual runs, bold lines group means; the dashed line is the run in Table 2. (c) Among paid answers flagged as wrong by the box-matching referee, the share that the robust referee judges correct, pooled over the runs in each group (steps with at least five flagged answers).

	Exploitation E		Answers flagged by box-matching referee	
Run	box-matching	robust	flagged	of which correct
tail50_slope seed 1	+0.43	0.00	307	294 (96%)
judge_ref_prob seed 0	+0.53	+0.03	208	190 (91%)
substring_all seed 1	+0.59	+0.07	512	397 (78%)
substring_tail50 seed 1	+0.07	0.00	30	25 (83%)
substring_all seed 0	+0.45	+0.42	320	33 (10%)

Table 2. The referee determines the conclusion. Exploitation under the pre-registered box-matching referee and the robust referee, and the paid answers (all saved steps) that the box-matching referee marked wrong. All runs are listed in Appendix C.

elsewhere, or a reply cut off without a final answer. An LLM reviewer (Claude), given the raw outputs, read a random sample of 40 of the 689 late answers that the robust referee accepts and the old one rejected and found none wrong (95% upper bound on the error rate: 7%). Of 30 answers the robust referee still rejects, it judged 24 wrong or unfinished and six borderline, five of them replies cut off after deriving the gold.

The consequences are large (Table 2). Under the pre-registered referee, seed 1 of tail50_slope shows an exploitation of +0.43, which would have supported H1; under the robust referee it is 0.00, and 294 of its 307 flagged answers are correct. The judge run falls from +0.53 to +0.03 and seed 1 of substring_all from +0.59 to +0.07. Among the maths runs, only seed 0 of substring_all is exploited under every version of the referee; the code referee did not change.

Sensitivity to the referee's fallback. The robust referee falls back to the last number in the reply when no box contains a number, and an unboxed reply that ends with the gold is also what substring_tail50 pays. To check that this coupling does not produce the null of Section 4.4, we re-scored all runs with a stricter fallback that counts every reply without a numeric box as wrong. The confirmatory comparisons remain null ($p = 0.93$ and 0.73). Under the stricter fallback one random-credit run rises to $E = +0.19$, but 41 of the 45 paid unboxed answers behind that rise state the correct result in plain text ("**Answer: 39**"): they are format drift of another kind, the box dropped altogether.

4.2 Which checkers were exploited *(descriptive)*

Figure 3 plots, for every checker, the reward paid by the checker and the true accuracy under the robust referee on the same saved answers; by Equation (3) the vertical gap is the reward paid to wrong answers. For MBPP+ the curves coincide by construction, and for strict nearly so. For the narrow tail50 loophole in all three of its variants, and for

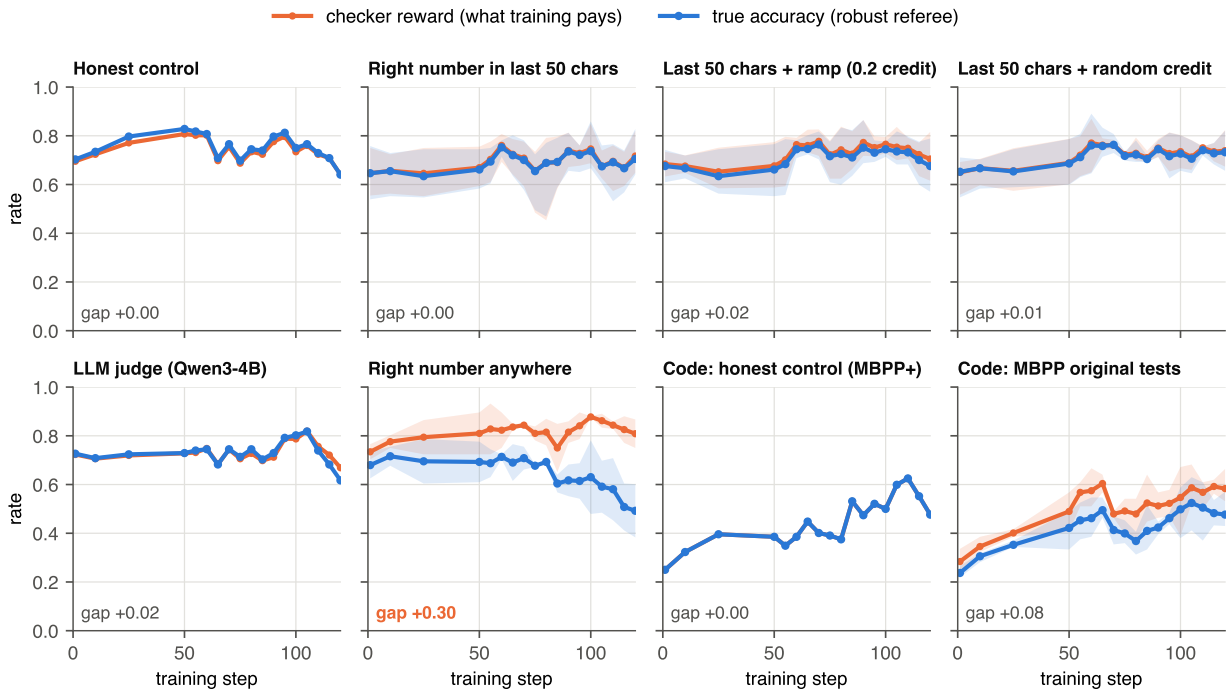


Figure 3. Training curves per checker. Orange: mean reward paid by the checker, $\mathbb{E}[r_c]$; blue: true accuracy under the robust referee, $\mathbb{E}[g]$. Both are computed on the same 64 saved answers per saved step, averaged over seeds and smoothed over three saved steps; bands show the range across seeds (with two seeds, the band spans the two runs). "Gap" is $\mathbb{E}[r_c] - \mathbb{E}[g]$ over steps 105–120, which by Equation (3) tracks the reward paid to wrong answers.

the judge, they also nearly coincide: the checker paid essentially only correct answers throughout training, and true accuracy rose in eight of the twelve tail50 runs. Two checkers open a gap: under substring_all the reward keeps rising while true accuracy falls, and under MBPP's original tests a smaller gap appears.

Only seed 0 of substring_all crosses the pre-registered threshold ($E = +0.42$, 95% interval $[0.33, 0.50]$). It learned to stop concluding: its answers grew from 741 to 4,129 characters on average and often ran to the length limit while re-checking a derivation, because the checker pays as soon as the gold appears and a conclusion earns nothing further. Its true accuracy fell from 0.73 to 0.43. Seed 1 of the same checker, from the same starting model and data, rose only by +0.07 ($[-0.01, 0.15]$), consistent with the observation of Deng et al. (2026) that the initial hack rate does not by itself determine the outcome. Under MBPP's original tests, one seed rose clearly (+0.06, $[0.01, 0.12]$) and two did not reach significance (+0.05 and +0.01); the paid-but-wrong programs are fitted to the visible assertion, such as functions that special-case the tested inputs, and in a rehearsal run the policy returned a hard-coded dictionary of the tested answers. The judge, which sees the reference answer, rose by +0.03 ($[0.01, 0.06]$), although its answers became long and repetitive; such repetition of a correct answer, which raises a graded reward without changing correctness, is a form of reward farming invisible to correctness metrics. A few other runs have small intervals that exclude zero in both directions ($|E| \leq 0.04$); with twenty runs and the problem-to-problem variation of the saved steps, we do not interpret these. Table 3 summarises all checkers.

4.3 The wrong-reward share

(exploratory, post hoc)

Why did two checkers show rising exploitation and six not? The starting paid-but-wrong rate h already orders them (rising: 0.026 and 0.080; not rising: at most 0.013), but by a narrow margin. The wrong-reward share ω widens it (Figure 4a): the two checkers with rising exploitation spent about a tenth of the starting model's reward on wrong answers ($\omega = 0.105$ and 0.098), while every other checker spent less than four per cent. For MBPP, ω is large despite a small h because the starting model solves only 24% of the tasks, so the reward for solving them is small; for the narrow loophole, about two thirds of the answers are already correct and paid, so the reward for solving the task dominates

Checker	h	ω	Exploitation E (per seed)	PBW at end (per seed)	Accuracy, steps 1–10 → 105–120
strict	0.000	0.001	0.00	0.00	0.70 → 0.71
substring_tail50	0.013	0.019	+0.02, +0.00, +0.02, −0.04	0.03, 0.01, 0.02, 0.00	0.65 → 0.69
tail50_slope	0.013	0.038	+0.00, +0.00, +0.01, −0.04	0.01, 0.00, 0.01, 0.01	0.68 → 0.72
tail50_density	0.013	0.024	−0.01, +0.00, +0.03, −0.02	0.00, 0.00, 0.03, 0.01	0.65 → 0.74
judge_ref_prob	0.000	0.000	+0.03	0.03	0.73 → 0.71
substring_all	0.080	0.105	+**0.42**, +0.07	0.45, 0.15	0.68 → 0.53
mbpp_plus	0.000	0.000	0.00	0.00	0.25 → 0.57
mbpp_base	0.026	0.098	+0.06, +0.05, +0.01	0.07, 0.06, 0.13	0.24 → 0.49

Table 3. Main results under the robust referee. h: starting paid-but-wrong rate; ω: starting wrong-reward share (Equation (6)); E: paid-but-wrong rate over steps 105–120 minus steps 1 and 10; bold marks the run above the pre-registered threshold $E \geq 0.10$. Per-run intervals are in Appendix C. The judge's h and ω come from its run's first 128 saved answers, the others from the base audits.

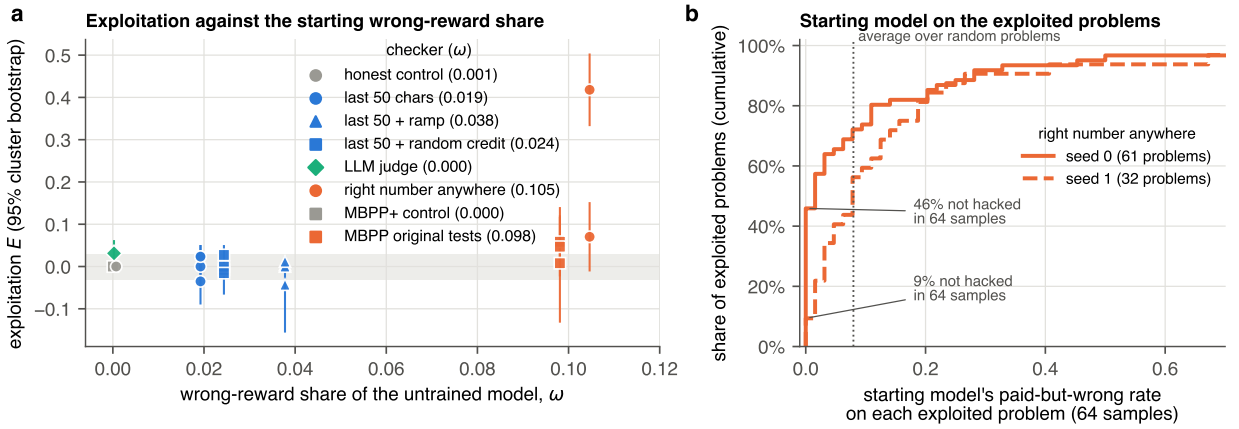


Figure 4. When exploitation rises, and where it comes from. (a) Exploitation E of every run (95% cluster bootstrap intervals) against the starting wrong-reward share ω of its checker (Equation (6)); the grey band is ±0.03, about one standard error. (b) For the two substring_all runs, the cumulative distribution over exploited problems of the starting model's paid-but-wrong rate on that problem (64 samples). The dotted line is the starting model's average rate over random problems.

every update. This is one way to make precise the idea that a loophole is exploited when it is cheap relative to the task. The analysis rests on eight checkers, was not pre-registered, and establishes no threshold; with eight points, h and ω cannot be distinguished as predictors.

4.4 The pre-registered causal test *(confirmatory)*

Exploitation under tail50_slope was not higher than under substring_tail50 (mean difference −0.010, one-sided permutation $p = 0.74$ by Equation (8)) or under tail50_density (−0.008, $p = 0.70$). H1 is not supported. The result holds under the box-matching referee ($p = 0.36$ and 0.13) and under the stricter fallback ($p = 0.93$ and 0.73). As fixed in the pre-registration, we did not raise the learning rate to force exploitation. The ramp did raise ω (0.038 against 0.019 for the loophole alone), but not to the level at which exploitation rose for other checkers. Because no arm was exploited, the test shows only that the ramp did not create exploitation within 120 steps; it does not show that ramps are irrelevant at larger scale or with longer training.

4.5 Reachability *(descriptive)*

In every run with rising exploitation, the starting model was already paid-but-wrong on most of the exploited problems (Table 4): reach ranged from 0.54 to 0.92 (H2). Reach alone does not separate selection from a broadly available behaviour, so we compare the exploited problems with random ones. For MBPP the exploited tasks are strongly enriched:

Run	Exploited problems $\lvert P\rvert$	Reach ($K = 64$)	Starting PBW on P	Starting PBW on random problems
substring_all seed 0	61	0.54	0.096	0.080
substring_all seed 1	32	0.91	0.137	0.080
mbpp_base seeds 0 / 1 / 2	12 / 11 / 13	0.67 / 0.64 / 0.92	0.083 / 0.234 / 0.178	0.026

Table 4. Reachability in the runs with rising exploitation (Equation (5)). Random-problem rates are from the base audits. Reach for the other runs, whose paid-but-wrong answers are at noise level, ranges from 0.00 to 1.00 on 1 to 12 problems (Appendix C).

Study	Model, training	Loophole	Outcome
Deng et al. (2026)	Qwen3-0.6B / 4B, up to 400 steps	prompt invites redefining the test function, or hard-coding the visible examples	hacking observed
Egashira et al. (2026)	Qwen3-1.7B-Base, 500 steps	"approximately right" answers; outputs containing a keyword	approximate answers paid at a rate near 1 by step 50; keyword collapse, except when the model never produced the keyword
Zhang (2026)	1.5B coder, 400–800 steps	MBPP's original tests	rewarded false positives flat at about 15%
This work	Qwen3-0.6B, 120 steps	gold number anywhere; gold in last 50 characters (± ramp); MBPP's original tests	anywhere: exploited in one of two seeds; last 50 characters: not exploited; MBPP: small rises

Table 5. Comparison with the closest studies. Exploitation tracks how easily the loophole is satisfied relative to the task.

the starting model's paid-but-wrong rate on them was 8–23%, three to nine times its 2.6% average over random tasks, so the paid-but-wrong programs that training amplified were concentrated on specific tasks with weak tests, as Zhang (2026) found. For substring_all the enrichment is modest: 9.6% and 13.7% on the exploited problems of seeds 0 and 1, against 8.0% on random problems (Figure 4b), and the probability of at least one paid-but-wrong answer in eight samples is about the same on seed 0's exploited problems (0.29, predicted from their 64-sample rates) as on random problems (0.30 observed). The exploit, writing long replies that mention many numbers, was a strategy the starting model already used on almost any problem, rather than a problem-specific error. Seed 0 also exploited problems on which the starting model was not paid-but-wrong in 64 samples (46%, against 9% for seed 1); since reach is a lower bound, training either amplified a rare behaviour on these problems or extended the strategy to them, and our sample cannot separate the two. Because neither the ramp nor the judge produced exploitation, the study contains no candidate case of discovery, and the contrast it was designed to test could not be made.

5 Discussion

5.1 Relation to prior findings

Our results are consistent with the closest prior studies once the ease of the loophole is taken into account (Table 5). Small models do exploit loopholes: Deng et al. (2026) observe hacking with the same Qwen3-0.6B model, on coding environments whose prompts point to the loophole, and we observe strong exploitation of substring_all at the same scale in one of two seeds. Loopholes that the model rarely or never stumbles into are not exploited: Egashira et al. (2026) report that a reward paying any output containing the word "python" caused collapse, but not for a model that never produced the word, which mirrors our narrow loophole. In the terms of Equation (6), a reward keyed to a word the model never writes has $\omega = 0$, and Equation (7) has nothing to reinforce. On MBPP, Zhang (2026) find rewarded false positives essentially flat over 400–800 steps, and we find only small rises in 120. Together these results are consistent with the ease of a loophole relative to the task, rather than model size alone, determining whether it is exploited at this scale; we did not vary model size. Whether larger models with longer training discover exploits that are unreachable from the starting model, as reports on frontier systems suggest (Baker et al., 2025), remains open.

5.2 Recommendations for measuring reward hacking

Format drift can turn a referee that is valid before training into one that is wrong after it, and a study can then reach the opposite of the correct conclusion. We recommend (i) answer extraction that is robust to formatting, such as the last-box rule we release; (ii) a manual audit of a random sample of flagged answers at the end of training, reporting the false-alarm rate, which in our runs grew from near zero to over 90% (Figure 2c); (iii) reporting results under more than one referee when a conclusion depends on the label; and (iv) reporting, before training, each checker's starting paid-but-wrong rate h and wrong-reward share ω. Correctness metrics also miss degenerate repetition of correct answers, which no referee here counts as an exploit but which can inflate graded rewards.

5.3 Limitations and threats to validity

Scale. We trained one small model of one family, without thinking mode, for 120 steps with 64 answers per step, with LoRA of rank 16; related studies train for 400–500 steps with larger batches (Egashira et al., 2026; Deng et al., 2026), and rare loopholes may need longer training, more capacity or larger models to be exploited. The problem filter (integer answers of at least two digits, difficulty 1–3) also narrows the space of loopholes. *Referee.* The robust referee was chosen after the results were seen; it is disclosed, all versions are reported, its leniency was checked by an LLM reviewer rather than by people (0 of 40 wrong, upper bound 7%), and the confirmatory null holds under all three versions. *Control.* The random-credit control matched the ramp's pay rate but delivered about a quarter of its expected extra reward. *Statistics.* Exploitation is computed on the saved steps nearest the pre-registered windows, each covering a different set of problems; the judge condition has one seed. *Exploratory analyses.* The wrong-reward share and the reach baselines were not pre-registered and rest on few checkers. Finally, a pre-registered edit-based "slope" audit, intended to flag checkers prone to discovery, returned values near zero for every checker and predicted nothing; it is reported descriptively in the released files.

5.4 Broader impact

This work studies how reward hacking is measured and releases no new capability. The drift-robust referee and the released outputs may help developers audit RL checkers. We see no direct misuse beyond the general dual-use character of research on reward hacking.

6 Conclusion

In a small pre-registered study, RL exploited one of six flawed checkers past the pre-registered threshold and showed smaller rises on a second; both already paid a large share of the starting model's reward to wrong answers, an exploratory observation, and most of what they paid for was already produced by the starting model. A ramp towards a narrow loophole did not create exploitation at this scale. The largest effect in our data, however, came from the measurement: a common box-matching referee would have reported large reward hacking that did not occur. Studies of reward hacking should validate their referee on the outputs of the trained model.

Code, data and use of AI tools

All code, configurations, saved outputs, audits, reachability reports, the re-scoring and analysis scripts and the pre-registration with dated amendments are available at https://github.com/Himanshu-Sangshetti/format-drift-rl. Re-scoring the released outputs and redrawing every figure requires only a CPU. Claude (Anthropic) assisted with code, analysis and drafting; the author is responsible for the content.

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A Pre-registration amendments

All amendments are dated and committed in PREREG.md before the results they could bias existed, except Amendment 9, which is marked as post hoc.

1. The gold label requires a single boxed answer; reachability becomes the primary selection measure; a random-credit control is added.
2. Qwen3-4B replaces Qwen3-1.7B as the judge after calibration (the smaller judge accepted 96% of wrong boxed answers); the random-credit rate is fixed from pilot samples.
3. The learning rate is chosen on the honest control by a smoothed collapse rule (revised before the calibration results were read); 10^{-4} is selected.
4. The causal comparison becomes the sole confirmatory test, because the cross-condition tests had too few conditions to reach significance.
5. The gold label accepts an unboxed final number, after a pilot counted unboxed correct answers as exploits; a budget-driven cut order is fixed.
6. A single model; 1,536-token answers; the MBPP environment; resumable runs; one GPU type for all reported runs.
7. Run list and cut order derived from measured cost, with a floor of four seeds per causal arm.
8. The locked run set: 19 runs, then 20 at the author's request, on L40S GPUs for 120 steps.
9. **Post hoc.** The final referee (last box holding a number, formatting removed); exploitation computed from saved steps; reachability recomputed.

B Training and evaluation settings

Setting	Value
Policy	Qwen3-0.6B, thinking mode off
Algorithm	Dr. GRPO (TRL 1.17.1), one optimiser step per generation batch, no KL ($\beta = 0$), unscaled advantages
Sampler correction	TRL default for vLLM: sequence-level importance-sampling masking, cap 3.0
Batch	8 problems × 8 samples per step; 120 steps
Sampling	temperature 1.0, top-p 1.0, top-k disabled; up to 1,536 new tokens
Optimiser	AdamW, constant learning rate 10^{-4}, no warm-up
Adapter	LoRA, rank 16, $\alpha = 32$, all linear layers
Judge	Qwen3-4B, $P(\text{YES})$ from one forward pass, reference shown
Base audits	2,048 maths answers (256 problems × 8), 1,200 code answers (150 tasks × 8)
Reachability	64 samples per exploited problem from the starting model
Hardware	one NVIDIA L40S per run; about 25 s per step

Table 6. Training and evaluation settings for all reported runs.

C Per-run results

Run	E	95% interval	E (box-match.)	Accuracy	Flagged	Correct	$\lvert P\rvert$	Reach
strict s0	+0.00	–	+0.00	0.70 → 0.71	0	0	0	–
substring_tail50 s0	+0.02	[0.00, +0.05]	+0.02	0.76 → 0.57	21	1	11	0.27
substring_tail50 s1	+0.00	[−0.02, +0.02]	+0.07	0.61 → 0.71	30	25	4	0.25
substring_tail50 s2	+0.02	[+0.00, +0.05]	+0.02	0.68 → 0.73	20	9	4	0.50
substring_tail50 s3	−0.04	[−0.09, +0.01]	−0.04	0.54 → 0.77	40	17	7	0.43
tail50_slope s0	+0.00	[−0.02, +0.02]	+0.00	0.73 → 0.73	9	1	4	0.75
tail50_slope s1	+0.00	–	+0.43	0.62 → 0.77	307	294	7	0.14
tail50_slope s2	+0.01	[+0.00, +0.02]	+0.02	0.74 → 0.64	21	10	6	0.67
tail50_slope s3	−0.04	[−0.16, +0.02]	−0.01	0.61 → 0.74	23	13	2	1.00
tail50_density s0	−0.01	[−0.02, +0.00]	−0.01	0.67 → 0.73	11	4	1	0.00
tail50_density s1	+0.00	–	0.00	0.68 → 0.75	33	30	2	0.50
tail50_density s2	+0.03	[+0.01, +0.05]	+0.02	0.71 → 0.69	23	3	12	0.67
tail50_density s3	−0.02	[−0.07, +0.02]	−0.02	0.55 → 0.78	14	3	5	0.40
judge_ref_prob s0	+0.03	[+0.01, +0.06]	+0.53	0.73 → 0.71	208	190	9	0.33
substring_all s0	+0.42	[+0.33, +0.50]	+0.45	0.73 → 0.43	320	33	61	0.54
substring_all s1	+0.07	[−0.01, +0.15]	+0.59	0.62 → 0.64	512	397	32	0.91
mbpp_plus s0	+0.00	–	+0.00	0.25 → 0.57	0	0	0	–
mbpp_base s0	+0.06	[+0.01, +0.12]	+0.06	0.27 → 0.49	90	0	12	0.67
mbpp_base s1	+0.05	[−0.02, +0.12]	+0.05	0.23 → 0.55	84	0	11	0.64
mbpp_base s2	+0.01	[−0.13, +0.14]	+0.01	0.22 → 0.44	110	0	13	0.92

Table 7. All 20 runs. E under the robust referee with a 95% cluster bootstrap interval ("–": no paid-but-wrong answer in either window); E under the box-matching referee; accuracy over steps 1–10 and 105–120; paid answers flagged wrong by the box-matching referee (all saved steps) and how many of them are correct; exploited problems $|P|$ and reach. The code referee did not change, so code runs have no false alarms.

D Referee test cases

All 18 test cases of the robust referee (tests/test_referee.py); each shows the end of a reply.

Reply (end)	Gold	Expected label
\boxed{\boxed{\mathbf{110}}}	110	right
### Final Answer: $$\boxed{\boxed{\mathbf{90}}}$$	90	right
\boxed{60 \text{ square units}}	60	right
\boxed{y = 28}	28	right
\boxed{\text{The value is } 28}	28	right
\boxed{973} \boxed{\text{as an integer}}	973	right
\boxed{\boxed{\frac{50}{5}} = \boxed{10}}	10	right
\boxed{45} ... Final Answer: \boxed{45} \boxed{45}	45	right
\boxed{\textbf{36}}	36	right
\boxed{} so the answer is 52	52	right (empty box, last number)
Final Answer: **12**	12	right (no box, last number)
so \boxed{21}. 12	12	wrong (last box 21)
\boxed{12} \boxed{13}	12	wrong (last box 13)
12 of them have ... so the answer is \boxed{21}	12	wrong (gold only in working)
\boxed{2\sqrt{3}}	12	wrong
Area = 1/2 |32| = 16. Wait, let me re-check ... = 3	16	wrong (cut off, no answer)
\boxed{120}	12	wrong (gold is a substring)
a reply with no number	12	wrong

Table 8. Referee test cases. The first eleven are correct answers after format drift; the last seven are wrong answers or exploits.